



Momentous occassion: The Puneri Paltan team celebrates with coach B.C. Ramesh after the final whistle. PKL

ever-reliable Jaideep Dahiya. Fuelled by the youthful audacity of Vinay and Shivam Patare, their offence was capable of igniting at the most opportune moment.

The players entered the arena, and the initial exchanges were a tense dance, with each team probing the other's defences and searching for weaknesses. Paltan struck first, their defence stifling the Steelers raiders with ease. But the Steelers refused to crumble, with Rahul Sethpal, a defensive rock, anchoring their line.

The first half was a masterclass in defensive strategies, with raids neutralised, tackles executed with precision, and points hard-earned. Then, a moment of brilliance

occurred as Pankaj Mohite, the silent assassin of Paltan, unleashed a super raid, earning four points.

The crowd erupted, but the Steelers weathered the storm via Vishal Tate, a last-minute substitute, who proved his mettle with a clutch raid, keeping his team alive. Ashish's last-second raid for the Steelers ensured they stayed within striking distance, with the score reading 10-13 at halftime.

The laser show at halftime was a mere interlude, with the second half beginning with a bang. Mohit Goyat inflicted an all-out on the Steelers, swinging the momentum decisively in Paltan's favour, but the young Steelers side refused to be cowed. Their raiders, emboldened by the spirit of the underdog, clawed their way back, picking up bonus points with acrobatic brilliance.

Mohite remained a constant threat for Paltan, with Gaurav Khatri, a rock at the back, stifling the Steelers' offence and slowing the game to a deliberate crawl. Every point became a battle, a fight for an inch on the mat. The score remained



Cornering the enemy: Puneri Paltan players tackle Haryana Steeler's raider Vinay. PKL

stubbornly close.

The final minutes were a nerve-wracking ballet of attack and defence, with Siddharth Desai, a late entrant for the Steelers, bringing back a flicker of hope, sending both Inamdar and Chiyaneh to the bench. But Paltan held firm with their defence.

Finally, the whistle blew, and Paltan were crowned champions, with a score of 28-25. Inamdar was declared the most valuable player (MVP) of the tournament. The Pune-based team won the title with a level of dominance unheard of in the 10 seasons of PKL, with only two defeats in 24 matches. Its revolutionary brand of Kabaddi has been revered as the most exciting by fans and pundits alike.

The Steelers, though defeated, walked away with their heads held high, their resilience earning them the respect of the Kabaddi faithful.

« After 75 days of intense action, the grand finale saw two teams from the traditional kabaddi heartlands of Maharashtra and Haryana compete for their first PKL title »